

money they'll make in a decade. I tell you, it's a little unsettling when I go out with my wife to an expensive restaurant and I see tables full of eighteen- to twenty-year-olds blowing \$40 each on an entrée. Good for them if they can afford it. But it's the wrong thing to be spending their money on, regardless. They should be at home (their *own* home, not their parents'), barbecuing with friends and socking that extra money away.

Historically, in tough economic times, a massive population shift was a critical way of fixing things. When there are no jobs in Michigan or Nevada, the country sends a message: Move to a city where jobs *are* aplenty. "Go West, Young Man" was a phrase coined in the late 1800s. It appeared on posters up and down the Eastern Seaboard, when cities were teeming with unemployed, restless young men recently returned from the Civil War. Instead of moving back home, find your "West" and go there.

Money Mistake: You Moved Back Home with Your Parents

THE FIX: BE PROACTIVE, PRODUCTIVE, AND, ABOVE ALL, GRATEFUL

Let's say it's too late—you've moved home. This is, after all, a purely financial decision. Very few twenty-two-year-old women or men relish the thought of watching TV with their parents and asking for permission to "sleep at a friend's house." It's demoralizing. So if this is you, I'm going to assume you did everything in your power to avoid this fate. Now it's time to get out of this situation as soon as possible. Let's be clear: We're talking about a temporary return to find your footing, or to recover from sudden job loss or illness. After all, that's what family does for one another. So don't feel guilty, but give yourself a deadline. Have it in writing *before* you approach Mom or Dad with your request to move back home. I can't stress this enough. Not having a plan means burning a lot of idle years in your pajamas. Food appears magically on a plate in front of you, laundry's folded and on your bed, and your parents are a lot nicer than they used to be. Snap